INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #3 · PARENTS

"What my parents said about me must be true."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Children believe what their parents say. If we were told we were lazy, stupid, selfish, ugly, or "just like" a difficult relative, those words went in deeply, and we may still repeat them to ourselves. A parent's words carry weight because they came at a time when we had no way to question them.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, "Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free." Paul writes, "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind." He also says, "We tear down arguments and every presumption set up against the knowledge of God; and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ." God says of you, "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made," and "we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works." A parent's words may have been repeated for years, but repetition does not make a statement true. Truth is tested against what God says.

> *"Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free"* (John 8:32).

Also see

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life" (Ephesians 2:10).

> "We tear down arguments and every presumption set up against the knowledge of God; and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ" (2 Corinthians 10:5).

> "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God" (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- They said I was worthless, so I must be.
- They know me best.
- I will always be the stupid one.
- I am exactly what they said I was.
- I cannot trust my own opinion of myself.
- If it was said so often, it must be true.

Common logical errors

- Authority bias: Accepting a statement as true because it came from a parent.
- Labeling: Carrying a childhood label into adulthood.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling flawed and treating the feeling as proof.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing evidence that contradicts the label.

Challenging questions

- What exactly did my parents say about me, in their words?
- Just because my parents said it, does that make it true?
- What evidence from my life supports it, and what contradicts it?
- What was going on in the parent who said it?
- What does God say about me instead?
- What would I say to a child who was told this?

Truth summary

> Words spoken over me are not the same as the truth about me. I can test what my parents said against Scripture and against the evidence of my life. God says I am fearfully and wonderfully made, and His word is the truth that sets me free.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Truth
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting
- Scripture/Word

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "What my parents said about me must be true"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What my parents said about me must be true." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly did my parents say?
- ☐ Is it true?
- ☐ What evidence contradicts it?
- ☐ What was happening in my parent?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ What would I tell a child who heard it?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A statement is not true just because a parent said it.
- ☐ God's word is the truth that sets me free.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I am God's workmanship.
- ☐ I can take captive every thought.
- ☐ I can renew my mind.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 8:32
  "Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free."
- ☐ Psalm 139:14
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 10:5
  "We tear down arguments and every presumption set up against the knowledge of God; and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Lie and truth: Each time an old parental message appears, write the message and a truth from Scripture to answer it.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Psalm 139:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am fearfully and wonderfully made, whatever I was told.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Thinking, Unhealthy" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write the messages. List what your parents said about you, one line each.
- ☐ Test each one. Beside each, write evidence for, evidence against, and what God says.
- ☐ Replace the label. Write a truthful sentence that replaces each message.
- ☐ Read your truth card daily. Read the replacement sentences aloud each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What my parents said about me must be true": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A lie answered
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What my parents said about me must be true.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, some words were spoken over me that I have believed for years. Show me what is true. Break the hold of every false message and renew my mind with Your word. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.